Women in Flames

By Mary Garripoli

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *Advances in American feminism have rarely happened smoothly.*
ACTRESS 2: *The gains of one generation have often both shaped and conflicted with the ambitions of the next.*
ACTRESS 1: *First-wave feminists fought for women's suffrage.*
ACTRESS 2: *Led in the 1970s by icons like Gloria Steinem and Betty Friedan, a second wave pushed for economic and legal gains.*
ACTRESS 1: *Their ideals would eventually clash with the spirited individualism of women in their 20s and 30s who still advocated for women's rights while embracing a "girlie culture."*
ACTRESS 1: *Welcome to 1969, as a mother and daughter try to bridge the generation gap and find common feminist ground.*
TOGETHER: *Women in Flames by Mary Garripoli*

It is the middle of the night. Annette enters. Unbeknownst to Annette, her mother, Doris is sitting on the other side of the room in the dark. Annette opens the front door. Before she can switch on the lights, the beam of a high voltage flashlight hits her.

DORIS: **(Pg 121-127)** Stay right where you are! Don't move a muscle.

ANNETTE: Mom?! It's me!

DORIS: I know who it is. Jump! Three inches off the ground, let's go!

ANNETTE: Mother, give me a break! I'm turning on the lights.

DORIS: Aha! I knew it! When you moved just now, I saw it with my own eyes. You're not wearing a bra, are you?!

ANNETTE: Mother?!

DORIS: I knew it! I knew it all along! Okay, let's have it. Spit it out! If you're not wearing them, then what have you done with my brassiers?

ANNETTE: Mom, it's the middle of the night. Can we talk about your brassiers in the morning?

DORIS: They're my brassiers, I'll talk about them when I want to . . . Well . . . I'm waiting.

ANNETTE: I burned them.

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DORIS: You what?!

ANNETTE: I burned them! ...At the Feminist rally outside the mayor's office last Saturday! I burned six of your bras and tied together three of your longline girdles to make a banner!

DORIS: You burned my underwear? In public?! Did anyone know it was MY underwear?

ANNETTE: Nobody knew! I didn't write your name on 'em!

DORIS: Why? Why did you do it?

ANNETTE: To liberate women from the oppression of men. We have to burn our bras to free ourselves! Is there a better way to celebrate Fourth of July?

DORIS: Is that a real question?

ANNETTE: Go ahead, make a joke! It's easier than listening to me.

DORIS: Don't start with me, I always listen to you! You think I'm nothing! That I'm not a part of life, that I don't matter. Well, this time you went too far!

ANNETTE: Sometimes you have to go far to get what you want!

DORIS: Look, I don't wanna fight with you. There's really only one thing I need to know---and I need to know so I can get some sleep, which believe me I also need---why my bras? Why burn my underwear to free yourself?

ANNETTE: Because I only own one bra and I need it for dance class. *(beat)* Can we finish talking about this tomorrow? I have to get to bed. They bombed the chem lab last week. I have three experiments to make up tomorrow.

DORIS: Come back here! You can't go to bed yet! Not with my underwear on your conscience! You owe me an apology.

ANNETTE: For what?

DORIS: For what? For stealing. You took something that was mine. I want remorse!

ANNETTE: Look, I'm sorry, okay? If I knew you were gonna get so bent about this . . .

DORIS: This is your apology?! This is how you feel when you break a commandment?

ANNETTE: I didn't think of it as stealing.

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DORIS: Whatta you call it? Borrowing? It's not borrowing because you can't give them back---except maybe in an urn!

ANNETTE: You really should be thanking me. You're asleep. Somebody had to wake you up.

DORIS: So now you're gonna play God and tell me how to think?

ANNETTE: You don't get what I'm about at all. You think this whole thing is about my stealing your underwear. . . which I did! Okay, alright!

DORIS: You are five minutes from being grounded!

ANNETTE: Fine, ground me! See if I care! Ground me for life!

DORIS: That's it! Pack up your love beads, you're outta here! You think I'm stupid. You think I don't know about Women's Liberation? I'm a wife and a mother. If that isn't the definition of "slavery" I don't know what is!

ANNETTE: Then join in with me, don't yell at me.

DORIS: What would I be joining?

ANNETTE: Mother, you're a woman----this is Feminism!

DORIS: Okay, so tell me about it. Tell me about Women's Liberation.

ANNETTE: First of all, call it what it is. Feminism. That's what we call it. Men call it Women's Liberation because. . . well. . .

DORIS: It's catchier?

ANNETTE: Very funny!

DORIS: Well, it is. It definitely has more of a ring to it.

ANNETTE: You think you're so funny, but you play right into that "Helpless Little Woman" s***!

DORIS: This is what you believe?

ANNETTE: This is what I know. Are you listening to me?

DORIS: I'm listening! I am listening! I listen to you more than you listen to me---more than your father listens to either of us! Whatta you want, Annette?

ANNETTE: I want to be everything I can be.

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DORIS: That's all I ever wanted for you. Maybe we're both feminists. Although I still can't see how my frying my underwear in the street is gonna make your father pick his up off the floor.

ANNETTE: See Mom, that's what I mean about you. You reduce everything down to something stupid.

DORIS: Well, I'm sorry Miss College Student---or should I say, "Ms."? It's the little everyday things that life's about, everything can't always be big, important issues.

ANNETTE: There's a lot more going on in the world than your laundry. You get more pissed off about dumb little stuff than you even do about the war. You really oughtta look at that.

DORIS: Don't tell me I don't get pissed about the war! Daddy and I fight about Jane Fonda at least twice a week!

ANNETTE: Daddy's a war monger!

DORIS: No, he isn't. He's a Veteran. When you were born, he bragged for months about how you have the same birthday as Mamie Eisenhower. He's a good guy---if he picked up his fruit of the looms, he'd be almost perfect.

ANNETTE: I can't believe Daddy would just refuse to pick up his underwear.

DORIS: It's not that he refuses, it's more like he can't get it. The same way he can't remember to put the toilet seat down so I don't sit in water when I go to the bathroom at night. Men are a mystery.

ANNETTE: Men are the same as us.

DORIS: That's the Women's Lib talking.

ANNETTE: Mom, you're a fossil. This is 1969, things are different now. I'm going to bed!

DORIS: I think I'll sit up a bit for Dad. He went to the fireworks at the V.F.W.

ANNETTE: You always sit up and wait for him. Just once, I wish you'd go out---make him wait up for you. You can walk out the door. You're a free woman.

DORIS: I've heard. But I can also see the fireworks from our window, and that's good enough for me, thank you. Goodnight, Annette.

ANNETTE: I'm sorry about your bras, Mom. I'll get you some new ones.

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DORIS: Apology accepted and you don't have to. Your father's gonna buy me all new clothes for our trip. We're going on vacation, him and me.

ANNETTE: You didn't tell me about it.

DORIS: I just decided. Actually, we're going ***because*** you burned my bras. See, when I went to get dressed this morning, I had to put on my blouse without a bra---we know why, let's not go into it again---and Daddy could tell.

ANNETTE: That you didn't have a bra on? So what?

DORIS: Netta, I don't flounce around without underwear like you do. No woman my age does. We weren't raised like that. I used to wear a girdle to bed before a big date! When your father didn't see a brassiere on me, he knew something was up. You know how he gets. All crazy in his head when he thinks there's something outta his royal domain. So I told him, "I lost all my bras, don't bug me!" So then we had a fight.

ANNETTE: About your bras?

DORIS: About my having an affair.

ANNETTE: What are you doing? You're thirty-six years old!

DORIS: Meaning what? No one would find me attractive?

ANNETTE: You know what I mean!

DORIS: No, I do not know what you mean. I'm not really what? Young anymore? I'm not pretty or sexy or ALIVE anymore?! No, Annette, I do not know what you mean! Or maybe more to the point, I don't care . . . The fireworks are almost over. Look! Come see them. I love the ones that streak across the moon. Their tales all full of color---like a comet or something. It takes guts to make a splash like that.

ANNETTE: Are you having an affair, Mommy?

DORIS: That's what your father wanted to know.

ANNETTE: Are you?

DORIS: Well, that's nobody's business but mine. I'm a free woman, remember? But since you asked, I'll tell you what I told him. No, I am not having an affair. Of course, I still couldn't explain how I'd lost my underwear. . .

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ANNETTE: I'll tell him what happened!

DORIS: You could do that. I wouldn't argue with you.

ANNETTE: You want him to think you're having an affair. . .

DORIS: I want a vacation. And. . . I wouldn't mind if he stayed home a few nights a week. . . and if once in a while he picked up his underwear. Even if he just did it out of fear. Sometimes you have to go far to get what you want.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Mary Garripoli
Book: The Best Stage Scenes of 1994, Pg 121-127
ISBN: 978-1880399668
Publisher: Smith & Kraus
Date (Month/Year): Jan 1995

AWARD HISTORY

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KS State Qualifier

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